

Daily Science Anecdotes

Topic: The Curtain That Moved

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Last night I watched a curtain move in a room with the windows closed. Nothing was there, but something was clearly pushing it. I stood there for a minute, a little unnerved, because I knew the push was real even though I couldn't see it.

Astronomers have been in that same room for almost a hundred years. In 1933, a scientist named Fritz Zwicky was watching a huge cluster of galaxies, and the numbers didn't add up. The galaxies were moving so fast that they should have been flung apart, like sparks off a spinning wheel. Yet the cluster held together. Something invisible had to be pulling on them with a gravity that no one could see.

Decades later, in 1970, Vera Rubin and Kent Ford measured how fast glowing clouds of gas circle the center of the Andromeda galaxy. If only the matter we can see were holding the galaxy together, the clouds far from the center should have moved more slowly, just as the outer planets orbit the Sun more slowly than the inner ones. They didn't. Their speeds stayed almost the same all the way out. Over the following years, Rubin and her colleagues found the same pattern in many more spiral galaxies. The curtain was moving again, and there was still no wind.

So how do you study a wind you can't see? You study what it does. Scientists use two great rules of gravity to do it.

Newton's law of Universal Gravitation

Newton showed that every object pulls on every other object, and that the pull depends on how much stuff there is and how far apart the objects are:

$$F = G \frac{m_1 m_2}{r^2}$$

Here F is the force of gravity, m_1 and m_2 are the masses of the two objects, r is the distance between them, and G is a constant that sets the strength of gravity. More mass means a stronger pull, and more distance means a weaker one. Using this rule, scientists can calculate how much pull the visible stars and gas should produce. The real pull turns out to be much bigger.

Einstein's General Relativity

Einstein went further. He said gravity isn't only a pull. It is the bending of space and time themselves. The physicist John Wheeler summed up the idea in one line:

*Matter tells space how to curve,
and curved space tells matter how to move.*

Picture a heavy ball resting on a stretched rubber sheet. The sheet dips, and anything rolling nearby curves toward the dip. Light has to follow the curves too, so when astronomers see the light of faraway galaxies stretched and warped on its way to us, they can measure how much mass is in the way. Again, there is far more than we can see. We call the missing part dark matter.

The strange part is that we still don't know what it is. Maybe it's a particle nobody has caught yet. Maybe our understanding of gravity is missing a piece. Nobody knows, and that is why it's one of the biggest mysteries in physics.

Tonight, when you look up at the stars and the Moon, remember that what you're seeing is only a small part of the story. Something we can't see may be shaping the whole universe around us. We just have to watch the curtain.

*If most of the universe is made of something we have never seen,
what else could be hiding in plain sight?*